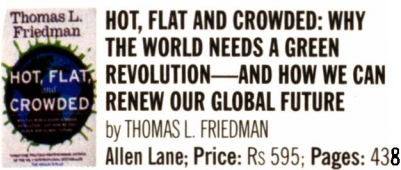


THE NEW CODE GREEN

Friedman's new book is as much about why the US has lost its groove as it is about energy and environment



■ By Raj Chengappa

Some books are a must read. Thomas L. Friedman's latest offering is one of them. As in a successful movie, book sequels too are a difficult act to pull through. Just a couple of years ago Friedman wowed the world with *The World is Flat* with both the originality and simplicity of his thesis. It was an idea that was waiting to be written about and Friedman did it long before it triggered light flashes in the mnemonic cells of other contemporary historians. In the sequel *Hot, Flat and Crowded*, Friedman steps into a territory that has already been charted by Al Gore and his Nobel Prize-winning effort. Friedman knows that he cannot compete with Gore's iconic status and his ability to inspire audiences across the globe. So although his latest book is about energy and the environment, as its rather long-winded subtitle enunciates, it is as much about America and why, as Friedman puts it, Americans choose to be "as dumb as we wanna be" about these two critical 21st century issues. It's an America that has lost its groove and Friedman's quest throughout the book is to ring the alarm so that Americans themselves would halt the slide and put their country back on track. It's a kick-butt approach that has America's ample behind as its prime target.

Everyone knows that America is the world's biggest emitter of greenhouse gases that is fuelling global warming

and bringing about a catastrophic change in the earth's climate. That its per capita emissions of such gases is 20 times that of India's. And that it is doing little to clean up its act—it didn't join the Kyoto Protocol that made it mandatory for developed nations to bring down their carbon dioxide emissions to 1990 levels. Instead of upbraiding the US for not fulfilling its international commitments, Friedman takes an entirely different tack. He appeals to the American sense of enterprise, innovation and leadership. To the conservatives, he says that he has a great plan to make the country strong again. To the liberals, he flaunts the Green dream. The end is the same but he marshals his thesis and uses the seductive power of his arguments to woo both sides.

Friedman is the master of common

COMMON SENSE GURU: Friedman

sense and is a sponge for detail. He brings to bear his considerable journalistic acumen and his travels across the globe to enrich his book with relevant real life examples that makes normally boring details come to life. He peppers his book liberally with his trademark one-liners such as "Green is the New Red, White and Blue". His central thesis is that the world is HOT because of global warming, FLAT because of the way India and China have emerged as leaders AND CROWDED because of the population explosion that has seen numbers treble in his own lifetime. According to him, the convergence of these three is driving five big problems: petrol-dictatorship (high oil prices are shifting the centre of gravity of the new Islam to the Middle-East), energy and natural resources supply and demand (what would the fate of the world be if the rest copied America's lifestyle?), climate change (global weirding in Friedmanspeak), biodiversity loss (Needed: a million Noahs and million Arks) and energy poverty (If it meets ET—energy technology—things would change).

He believes that instead of a Manhattan project, what is needed is the Market. That price signals including a tax on carbon would put the US on the path to reform and finally to leadership in clean technology that would dominate the 21st century. But this is where Friedman begins to falter. His over reliance on market factors appears a bit naïve in the light of Wall Street's recent collapse. Nor does he seem clear what would be the tipping point for America to move to "Code Green". Yet overall it's a book rich with ideas, anecdotes and analysis that gives you plenty to think about. And put to action. ■



BANCEEP SINGH